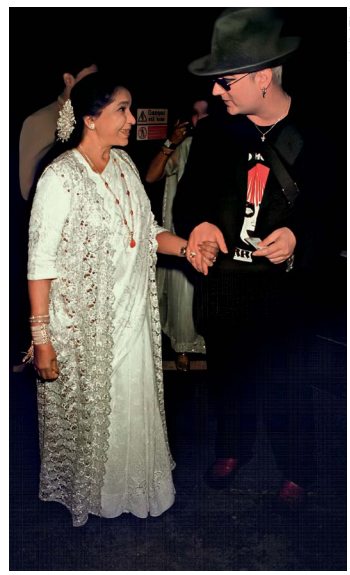






ALAMY

‘SHE WAS A GENRE HERSELF’



ADNAN SAMI
Singer and musician

For me, Ashaji was far more than a legend. I met her for the first time when I was about 10. She was touring London with R.D. Burman. I remember she opened the concert with ‘Chura liya hai’. So overwhelmed was I by the aura of her voice that I started crying. I just looked up and said, “God, please one day make me worthy enough to be able to sing and perform with her.” She created a beautiful persona on stage.

I remember when we were recording ‘Kabhi to nazar milao’. She was uncharacteristically quiet. I asked her why. She said she was thinking if she’d able to pull it off. She said every work is a new challenge and there’s lot more for her to learn. But the moment she came in front of the microphone, a melodious monster would emerge. She would give you variations to the point where you would feel like a kid in a candy shop. The kind of training she had, one could make her do all those things that nobody else could pull off.

There were some fascinating things about her—zeal for life, strength, determination, an eternally youthful soul. Apart from the professional lessons I learnt from her—how to face the microphone, how to express—she taught me a lot about life. The foundations she laid down for Indian music and her contribution can never be over emphasised. She was a genre unto herself.

—*As told to* ***SUHANI SINGH***

Bhosle’s most recent association, at age 92, with virtual band Gorillaz in their album *The Mountain* underlines her enthusiasm for creating new music

the most eclectic international artistes. Brit pop singer Boy George persuaded her to lend vocals to his track ‘Bow Down Mister’ in 1991. While it got a lot of attention, its racialised music video and lyrics were overlooked, making Bhosle’s *alaap* perhaps its only redeeming quality. But later international collaborations were far from questionable. San Francisco-based string ensemble, Kronos Quartet, who worked with Bhosle for the album *You’ve Stolen My Heart* (2005), a collection of rearranged string versions of Burman’s biggest hits, received a Grammy nomination in the Best Contemporary World Music Album category. But it’s Bhosle’s most recent association with Gorillaz that underlines her enthusiasm for creating new music. The 92-year-old featured on the track ‘The shadowy light’, on the band’s ninth studio album *The Mountain*. While it is a reflection on life and death, Bhosle’s lines—*‘Chal mere maajhi/ gehra hai paani, mujhe jaana uss paar/ Jahan sukh ho, naa dukh ho/ Jahan jai ho, naa haar ho* (Come, boatman, I’ve to cross these deep waters/ where there is happiness, not grief, victory, not defeat)’—sound like she was bidding farewell in the way she knew best: with a song. ■

The author is the former editor of Rolling Stone India *magazine who has written about music in the subcontinent for over two decades and is currently pursuing a doctorate in English at Michigan State University*